

Nicomachean Ethics - Aristotle

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Book I:

Aristotle defines “the function of man” as an “activity of the soul”, saying that our actions are a rational reflection of one’s soul. As such he believes in the existence of a “human good” because with any action/function there are distinction between one who performs the function and one who performs the function well.

Example Aristotle gave is of a lyre-player. Those who can play the lyre are lyre players, while those who can play the lyre well are “good” lyre-players. As such, he extends this rational to the idea that there exists those who live a “good” life.

Aristotle notes that this *human good* needs to be a continued act in accordance to this virtue, that we will define later, and not simply a one-off.

“For one swallow does not make a summer, nor does one day; and so too one day, or a short time, does not make a man blessed and happy.” (Pg 52)

Book II:

Book II is Aristotle needing to “examine the nature of actions, namely how we ought to do them” (Pg 67)

He notes that this should be an agreed upon outline but not to precise since actions per matter have no “fixity”

Talks about excess and deficit, saying either path can destroy a man (exercise, food/drink, cowardice vs reckless, pleasure/ self-indulgence vs abstinence). Aristotle uses these examples to demonstrate that to live virtuously is to live between the extremes at the mean.

“Virtue, then, is a state of character concerned with choice, lying in a mean, i.e. the mean relative to us, this being determined by a rational principle, and by that principle by which the man of practical wisdom would determine it.” (84)

Aristotle’s golden mean

Aristotle notes that not all actions have a mean, with some already implying good/badness like adultery, theft, and murder. So Aristotle believes that there are certain things that should simply not be pursued because the actions themselves omit the negative connotation and not excess or deficiency of the action / passion.

Book III:

This section is all on rational, irrational and mixed principle. He opens with:

“Since virtue is concerned with passions and actions, and on voluntary passions and actions praise and blame are bestowed, on those that are involuntary pardon, and sometimes also pity, to distinguish the voluntary and the involuntary is presumably necessary for those who are studying the nature of virtue, and useful also for legislators with a view to the assigning both of honors and of punishments” (80)

Aristotle defines involuntary actions as those that compulsory or from ignorance should not be contributed to the actor. However, actions in response to a greater evil could be either (voluntary or involuntary) so he deems them as *mixed* actions.

Gives the example of throwing cargo overboard during a storm to save the crew.

While Aristotle believes that actions by reason of ignorance are involuntary thus excusable, actions done in ignorance are not as clear cut. A “wicked man” (82) is ignorant of what he should/shouldn’t do. A man may be ignorant of:

1. Who he is
2. What he is doing
3. What or whom he is acting on
4. What instrument he is using
5. What end (thinks his act will conduce to safety)
6. How he is doing it (gently or violently)

Synthesis:

Aristotle believes in this notion of a *human good* or *happiness* which is intertwined with living a virtuous life. He believes that in order to live a virtuous life one must live near this golden mean and must not live in excess. However, Aristotle recognizes that some actions are involuntary and that we should strive live a virtuous life through our own agency (voluntary actions).

Discussion Questions:

Do you believe in Aristotle’s notions of *human good* and what does it mean to you? (Or how do you define living a good life?)

Do you agree with Aristotle that the way to live a life of virtue is the habitual pursuit of the “mean” between excess and deficiency? Can a person be virtuous while not at the mean and/or what other criteria do you think play into a virtuous life?

What distinctions do you have between Aristotle’s categories of voluntary, involuntary and mixed actions? (Or is there a secret 4th option, or do you disagree with his category theories as a whole)